

Questions 46 to 50 are based on the following passage.

Nationally, one in six children miss 15 or more days of school in a year. Education officials have deplored all this missed instruction.

These chronically absent students suffer academically because of all the classroom instruction they miss out on. In 2015, the U.S. secretary of education responded to this crisis, urging communities to support every student to attend every day and be successful in school. His open letter stated that missing 10% of school days in a year for any reason—excused or unexcused—is a primary cause of low academic achievement.

Worrying about whether children attend school makes sense. After all, if students don't show up, teachers can't teach them.

But what if America's attendance crisis is about much more than students missing class? What if, instead, it is a reflection of family and community crises these students face—such as being ejected from the family apartment, fearing for their safety in their neighborhood or suffering an illness?

As social scientists we investigated how excused and unexcused absences relate to children's academic achievement.

We find that absences excused by a parent do little to harm children's learning. In fact, children with no unexcused absences—but 15 to 18 excused absences—have test scores equal to their peers who have no absences.

Meanwhile, the average child with even just one unexcused absence does much worse academically than peers with none.

We believe unexcused absence is a strong signal of the many challenges children and families face, including economic and medical hardships. Unexcused absences can be a powerful signal of how those out-of-school challenges affect children's academic progress.

Our evidence suggests unexcused absences are problematic, but for a different reason than people often think. Absence from school, and especially unexcused absence, matters mainly as a signal of many crises children and their families may be facing. It matters less as a cause of lower student achievement due to missed instruction.

How we choose to think of school absences matters for educational policy. School attendance policies typically hold schools and families accountable for the days children miss, regardless of whether they were excused or unexcused absences.

These policies assume that missing school for any reason harms children academically because they are missing classroom instruction. They also assume that schools will be able to effectively intervene by reducing student absences. We find neither to be the case.

As a result, these attendance policies end up disproportionately punishing families dealing with out-of-school crises in their lives and pressuring schools who serve them to get students to school more often.

We instead suggest using unexcused absence from school as a signal to channel resources to the children and families who need them most.

46. What does the U.S. secretary of education say in his open letter?

- A) It is of vital importance to respond promptly to the school absence crisis.
- B) The academic performance of chronically absent students is deplorable.
- C) Low academic achievement is mainly attributed to school absences.
- D) The effect of school absences on American education is worrisome.

47. What do the authors find about school absences?
- A) Excused school absences have little impact on children's learning.
 - B) There is little difference between unexcused and excused absences.
 - C) Excused absences lead to comparatively better school performance.
 - D) Unexcused absences are a big challenge to both schools and families.
48. What do the authors believe concerning unexcused school absences?
- A) They are likely to cause a decrease in students' academic achievements due to missed instruction.
 - B) They point directly to many of the out-of-school challenges confronting children and their families.
 - C) They are matters the American government typically ignores when formulating educational policies.
 - D) They give a clear signal to children and their families of the crises they are likely to face in the future.
49. What is the assumption underlying education policies in the U.S.?
- A) Children's academic performance depends on reducing the number of absences.
 - B) Schools can boost children's academic performance by effective intervention.
 - C) Schools as well as families should be held responsible for out-of-school crises.
 - D) Children's academic performance is closely related to the quality of instruction.
50. What do the authors suggest doing regarding school absences?
- A) Identifying their underlying causes.
 - B) Reframing school attendance policies.
 - C) Directing resources to helping needy children.
 - D) Pressuring schools to reduce unexcused ones.

Passage Two

Questions 51 to 55 are based on the following passage.

After earning a bachelor's degree, I was determined to do what I love. I headed straight to graduate school to investigate the social problems that fascinated me.

For almost a decade, I told everyone I encountered that they should do the same. "Follow your passion," I counseled. "You can figure out the employment stuff later."

It wasn't until I began to research this widely accepted career advice that I understood how problematic it really was.

As a sociologist, I interviewed college students and professional workers to learn what it really meant to pursue their dreams, which I will refer to here as the passion principle. I was stunned by what I found out about this principle in the research for my new book.

Surveys show the American public has long held the passion principle in high regard as a career decision-making priority. And its popularity is even stronger among those facing job instability.

Advocates of the passion principle found it compelling because they believed that following one's passion can provide workers with both the motivation necessary to work hard and a place to find fulfillment.

Yet, what I found is that following one's passion does not necessarily lead to fulfillment, but is one of the most powerful cultural forces perpetuating overwork. I also found that promoting the pursuit of one's passion helps perpetuate social inequalities due to the fact that not everyone has the same economic resources to allow them to pursue their passion with ease.

While the passion principle is broadly popular, not everyone has the necessary resources to turn their passion into a stable, good-paying job. Passion-seekers from wealthy families are better able to wait until a job they are passionate about comes along without worrying about student loans in the meantime. They are also better situated to take unpaid internships to get their foot in the door while their parents pay their rent. And they often have access to parents' social networks to help them find jobs. Surveys revealed that working-class and first-generation college graduates, regardless of their career field, are more likely than their wealthier peers to end up in low-paying unskilled jobs when they pursue their passion.

Colleges, workplaces and career counselors who promote the “follow your passion” path for everyone, without leveling the playing field, help perpetuate socioeconomic inequalities among career aspirants.

It's not just well-off passion-seekers who benefit from the passion principle. Employers of passionate workers do, too. Potential employers showed greater interest in passionate applicants in part because they believed the applicants would work hard at their jobs without expecting an increase in pay. They even sacrifice a good salary, job stability and leisure time to work in a job they love.

51. What did the author advise people do for almost a decade?

- A) Figure out what is the most fascinating job.
- B) Follow widely accepted career counsel.
- C) Pursue their careers with passion.
- D) Do whatever they are zealous for.

52. How did the author feel about the passion principle through his research?

- A) He was astonished by its consequences.
- B) He was further convinced of its soundness.
- C) He was actually right to follow it through.
- D) He was struck by its broad popularity.

53. What is important to turning one's passion into a stable, good-paying job?

- A) Willingness to take unpaid internships and low-paying jobs.
- B) Full academic preparedness and sound career counseling.
- C) Hard work and sacrifice of leisure time.
- D) Financial backing and social connections.

54. What happens when everyone is encouraged to follow their passion?

- A) Many more career aspirants end up unemployed.
- B) People are less concerned with socioeconomic inequality.
- C) Socioeconomic inequality is likely to persist.
- D) Career counselors are going to lose credibility.

55. What does the author say about employers of passionate workers?

- A) They provide these workers with job stability and a good salary.
- B) They exploit these workers' passion to benefit themselves.
- C) They level the playing field for these workers to reach their goals.
- D) They encourage these workers to realize their aspirations.